Indian Shipping after SSNCo

The British India Steam Navigation Company continued to flourish and became even bigger under Lord Inchcape who manoeuvred its amalgamation with P&O in 1916.

In Tuticorin, A. & F. Harvey continued to hold sway. Though the surviving brother Andrew died in 1915, ten years after the passing away of the younger Frank, their dominance continued into the early years after Indian Independence. Unlike in 1908, when there was only the Tuticorin Chamber of Commerce which represented European interests exclusively, by the early 1920s an Indian Chamber of Commerce was established. But that did little to change the ground reality. Complaints remained of the high-handed way the BI's Tuticorin Agents treated the local merchants.[10] In the context of the troubles faced by the Scindia Steam Navigation Company, more than a decade after the collapse of SSNCo, a trader from Tuticorin recalled how Swadeshi companies were crushed by ruthless rate wars by foreign firms.[11] Now of course, there was no VOC to run to. Further, BI (and the Asiatic Steam Navigation Company) refused to entertain survey certificates issued by the Indian chamber—a privilege that remained exclusively with the European chamber of commerce.[12]

If BI and the Harvey Bros thrived, it could not have been good news for Indian shipping. Did Indian shipping revive after the SSNCo debacle? Two extensive reports of the early 1920s throw light on this. But before we turn to it, reference needs to be made of the only successful—even if it was a qualified success—Indian shipping venture in pre-Independence India: the Scindia Steam Navigation Company.[13]

Soon after World War I, in 1919, Narottam Morarjee (1877–1929), a textile magnate of Bombay, joined hands with Walchand Hirachand (1882–1853), a cotton trader and moneylender, to start the Scindia Steam Navigation Company. These two Gujarati businessmen were joined by Lalubhai Samaldas (1863–1936) and Mansukhram Atmaram Master (1884–1970). Registered as a joint-stock company, Scindia had an authorized capital of Rs 4.5 crore. The lessons of Tuticorin were well learnt, as is